



emerges lower down the slope. The drought-resistant flora includes oleanders, tamarisks, and the endangered sea lavender.

The Stone Desert

Location Varna depression, northeast Bulgaria

This area of low rainfall and sparse vegetation is Bulgaria's only desert. It is best known for the Pobiti Kamani (hammered stones)—18 groups of upright limestone columns up to 22 ft (7 m) tall and 10 ft (3 m) in diameter. The most popular theory that explains this phenomenon is that methane-bearing fluids seeping up shafts to an ancient ocean floor were

oxidized by bacteria to form cylinders of calcium carbonate. Subsequent uplift of the region and erosion of the softer, sandy sediments around the cylinders has left them standing prominently.

Africa

The Erg Chebbi Sand Dunes

Location Erfoud, Sahara Desert, eastern Morocco

Erg Chebbi is one of two large ergs—seas of dunes composed of windblown sand with little or no vegetation—in the Moroccan Sahara. Its biggest dunes rise 490 ft

(150 m) above the surrounding desert. Erg Chebbi extends about 17 miles (28 km) from south to north and 4 miles (7 km) from west to east. Daytime temperatures soar to 104°F (40°C) in July, but at night in winter they may fall to 37°F (3°C). The wettest month of the year is November, with just ½ in (10 mm) of rain. Despite the aridity, reptiles and nocturnal mammals such as jerboas and fennec foxes live here.

The Nyiri Desert

Location South of Nairobi, southern Kenya

Also known as the Nyika Desert and the Tarud Desert, the Nyiri

Desert lies north of Mount Kilimanjaro and encompasses Amboseli National Park, including the northern half of Lake Amboseli. The annual rainfall averages 14 in (350 mm), but outside of the brief rainy season in April and May, water is scarce in this region, being restricted to a few springs and riverbeds. Vegetation comprises a mixture of grassland and thorn scrub (including some poisonous plants), with scattered baobab trees—some more than 2,000 years old, their circular trunks often as much as 10 ft (3 m) in diameter. Large mammals include giraffes, lions, leopards, and the lesser kudu and impala. More than 400 species of birds are residents or migrants, including 47 different types of raptors.